



All for One and One for All

Gaming consoles are all set to be transformed from single-utility gaming machines to multifunctional devices that will significantly blur the differences between themselves, the PC and home consumer electronics

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Convergence. You've heard it, I've heard it, and it's coming. Simply put, convergence is the consolidation of a wide range of technologies and devices into a single, more open device. Which means that you will be able to do a lot more with any one device.

For example, Interactive TV merges the convenience of the Internet with regular television and the cellular phone in your pocket acts as your PDA and MP3 player. But what fascinates me is the extremely rapid pace at which technology and entertainment are converging.

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Next generation console systems are positioning themselves as general-purpose entertainment devices rather than mere video game machines. With home theatre functionality, USB and FireWire (iLink) ports, expansion bays, and online connectivity, these 'toys' are on an inevitable collision course with home consumer electronics. In fact, Sony is going out of its way to re-christen the PS2 as a central hub for home entertainment, facilitating all aspects of digital entertainment from electronic gaming, home audio/video, to Internet browsing and even doubling up as a digital video recorder. Not bad for a \$300 game box, is it?

Sony's new alliances with America Online, RealNetworks and Macromedia will bring the PS2 one step closer to becoming a true Internet Appliance with Web browsing, e-mail, streaming media and instant messaging. I for one am eagerly looking forward to this, as now I'll be able to beat the stuffing out of some PS2 user in *Quake* and taunt him on Instant Messenger till he either blocks me or logs off my Internet!

Microsoft's much-hyped Xbox is the first game console to feature built-in broadband connectivity and a beefy hard drive. Running a derivative of the Windows 2000 OS, the Xbox can easily be mistaken for a high-end PC at a low-end price. Remember the commotion when Netpliance's i-opener Internet Appliance was modified to function as a Linux-based PC? I'm sure that someone will figure out a way to unleash the true potential from this Pentium powered box.

With Sega announcing that it plans to license out the Dreamcast technology to consumer electronic manufacturers and VM Lab's NUON providing 3D interactive graphics and audio to DVD players, set-top boxes and digital satellite receivers, single-function appliances will become a thing of the past. Soon we won't need to spend money for each individual device since these new age appliances will combine a host of functions.

Digital entertainment will finally become a de facto part of every home, since the largest barrier is the cost of these various technologies and not their acceptance.

Another interesting parallel is that these game boxes will soon provide a real threat to the dominance of traditional beige boxes that sit on your desk. The most widespread uses of Home PCs are productivity applications, surfing the Internet and using multimedia content. With Internet connectivity, bucketloads of storage space, USB ports and a \$300 (approx Rs 15,000) price tag, I'm sure that these over-the-top consoles will soon be replacing the PC in many a home. Convenience is an important factor too. Gaming machines will provide the perfect starting platform for the technologically challenged. It doesn't take a genius to figure out how they work—switch power on and put disk in drive.

As technologies for gaming consoles become more and more PC-like, I believe that these beefed-up game consoles are the best candidates to fulfil the promise of convergence of PCs and other home electronics! ■

Vinit Aggarwal (Editor, Computer Gaming World) loves slapping anyone who calls gaming an indulgence for children. You can contact him at vinit_aggarwal@jasubhai.com